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Habit 5. Fear God

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Habit 5. Fear God

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As you get to know God better, you will also develop reverential respect for His holy nature. It's possible for us to have a love relationship with God, but to not give Him the respect that He is due — the respect that He demands.

We can't live the way that God wants us to live apart from really understanding what it means to fear God. We can't really learn what God wants us to learn apart from having that kind of attitude. And we certainly cannot worship Him the way that He deserves to be worshiped.

What does it mean to fear God?

The term for fear can describe everything from dread or being terrified, to standing in awe or having reverence. When used of the Lord, it applies to both aspects of the term, a shrinking back in recognition of the difference or holiness of God and drawing close in awe and worship. It is an attitude of both reluctance and adoration that results in a willingness to do what God says. The fear of the Lord, then, is absolutely necessary if we are even to begin on the right foot in learning, living, or worshiping. (From Hard Sayings of the Bible)

Do you revere God's awesome holiness? Moses displayed a healthy fear of God's greatness when he prayed, "Who is like you, O Lord, among the gods? Who is like you—majestic in holiness, fearful in praises, working wonders?" (Exodus 15:11)

Why should we fear God?

God's greatness demands our reverential respect.

"From the north he comes in golden splendor; around God is awesome majesty. As for the Almighty, we cannot attain to him! He is great in power, but justice and abundant righteousness he does not oppress. Therefore people fear him, for he does not regard all the wise in heart." – Job 37:22-24

God's Word demands our reverential respect.

"You stood before the Lord your God at Horeb and he said to me, 'Assemble the people before me so that I can tell them my commands. Then they will learn to revere me all the days they live in the land, and they will instruct their children.'" – Deuteronomy 4:10

God's works demand our reverential respect.

"And all people will fear. They will proclaim what God has done, and reflect on his deeds." – Psalm 64:9

We demonstrate a healthy fear of God. . .

When we treat others rightly.

“and submitting to one another out of reverence for Christ.” – Ephesians 5:21

When we live righteous lives.

“The fear of the Lord is to hate evil; I hate arrogant pride and the evil way and perverse utterances.” – Proverbs 8:13

When we obey God’s commands.

“If only it would really be their desire to fear me and obey all my commandments in the future, so that it may go well with them and their descendants forever.” – Deuteronomy 5:29

When we serve Him.

“Serve the Lord in fear. Repent in terror.” – Psalm 2:11

When we teach others to respect God.

“Come children. Listen to me. I will teach you what it means to fear the Lord.” – Psalm 34:11

When we worship Him.

“Who will not fear you, O Lord, and glorify your name, because you alone are holy? All nations will come and worship before you for your righteous acts have been revealed.” – Revelation 15:4

Those who have a reverential fear of God enter into a special relationship with specific blessings.

Promises for those who fear God...

“The Lord shows his faithful followers the way they should live. They experience his favor; their descendants inherit the land. The Lord’s loyal followers receive his guidance, and he reveals his covenantal demands to them.” – Psalm 25:12-14

“How great is your favor, which you store up for your loyal followers. In plain sight of everyone you bestow it on those who take shelter in you.” – Psalm 31:19

“Look, the Lord takes notice of his loyal followers, those who wait for him to demonstrate his faithfulness” – Psalm 33:18

“The angel of the Lord camps around the Lord’s loyal followers and delivers them. Taste and see that the Lord is good. How blessed is the one who takes shelter in him. Fear the Lord, you chosen people of his, for those who fear him lack nothing.” – Psalm 34:7-9

“But the Lord continually shows loyal love to his faithful followers, and is faithful to their descendants” – Psalm 103:17

“He gives food to his faithful followers; he always remembers his covenant.” – Psalm 111:5

“You loyal followers of the Lord, trust in the Lord. He is their deliverer and protector. The Lord takes notice of us; he will bless—he will bless the family of Israel, he will bless the family of Aaron. He will bless his loyal followers, both young and old.” – Psalm 115:11-13

“How blessed is every one of the Lord’s loyal followers, each one who keeps his commands.” – Psalm 128:1

“He satisfies the desire of his loyal followers; he hears their cry for help and delivers them.” – Psalm 145:19

“The Lord takes delight in his faithful followers, and in those who wait for his loyal love.” – Psalm 147:11

“Through loyal love and truth iniquity is appeased; through fearing the Lord one avoids evil.” – Proverbs 16:6, NIV

“The reward for humility and fearing the Lord is riches and honor and life.” – Proverbs 22:4, NIV)

“From generation to generation he is merciful to those who fear him.” – Luke 1:50

Therefore. . .

“O Lord, teach me how you want me to live. Then I will obey your commands. Make me wholeheartedly committed to you.” – Psalm 86:11

“And if you address as Father the one who impartially judges according to each one’s work, live out the time of your temporary residence here in reverence.” – 1 Peter 1:17

“Who among you fears the Lord? Who obeys his servant? Whoever walks in deep darkness, without light, should trust in the name of the Lord and rely on his God.” – Isaiah 50:10

“The beginning of wisdom is to fear the Lord, and acknowledging the Holy One is understanding.” – Proverbs 9:10

Ask the Holy Spirit to open your eyes with renewed understanding to these incredible truths and to help you grow in reverence of God.